



MBENDJELE

PYGMY PEOPLE OF THE RAIN FOREST

AS MANY AS 200,000 DIFFERENT GROUPS live in the forests of central Africa in countries such as Zaire, Gabon, Cameroon, Central African Republic, and Uganda. They are sometimes known collectively as

Women's work

Mbendjele women gather fruit, nuts, mushrooms, tubers, and caterpillars. They are not permitted to kill animals by drawing blood so rather than shoot, they fish or catch and kill small animals by clubbing them. At harvesttime women help gather in the crops for their settled neighbors in return for a share of the harvest.

MAKING MONGOLÉ

A woman prepares a red paste called *mongolé*, which is said to have protective and magical powers. It is made by adding nut oil to the powder produced when two sticks of dead wood are ground together with a little sand and water. *Mongolé* is rubbed onto babies to make them grow strong, and onto young adults during their most vulnerable time—initiation.



RAIN FOREST KITCHEN

Mbendjele groups move camp around 30 times a year. Fortunately, it only takes minutes to set up a new kitchen. Elderly women carry smoking embers wrapped in leaves to the new camp so it is easy to start a fire on arrival. The family machete and cooking pot are carried in the basket belonging to the woman of the family. The heavy mortar and pestle are either left at the site for next time the group returns or made anew. Chopping boards and plates are simply readily available wood and leaves.

A CURE FOR ILLNESS

Mokodis are strings woven from tree bark, vines, and other forest materials. They are made by both women and men, and are worn on the affected part of the body to cure illness. Special *mokodis* are tied around the wrists and waists of newborn babies to protect them.



Hunters must be absolutely silent so as not to alarm the animals. They communicate using signs like this one which means "elephant."